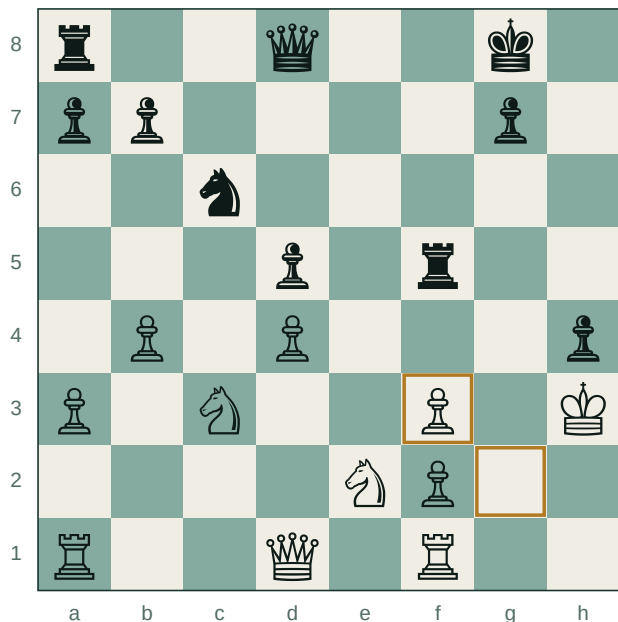


Exposed-king tactics: Black, move 22

Exposed-king tactics

Black to move



Previous move: 22.gxf3. Gold borders mark its start and finish.

WORKED CONTINUATION - COVER THIS SECTION FIRST

22...Rxf3+ 23. Kg2 Qg5+ 24. Kxf3 Rf8+ 25. Nf4 Rxf4+

22...Rxf3+ Check restricts White to 4 legal replies here. From f3 it attacks king on h3 and knight on c3. Recorded reply: **23.Kg2**.

23...Qg5+ Check restricts White to 4 legal replies here. Recorded reply: **24.Kxf3**.

24...Rf8+ Check restricts White to 1 legal reply here. Recorded reply: **25.Nf4**.

25...Rxf4+ Check restricts White to 2 legal replies here. The move also takes the knight on f4.

At the end, nominal material is White 26 / Black 22 (P=1, N/B=3, R=5, Q=9). Over this line, Black's balance changes by -1. Activity and king safety still affect the evaluation.

CHECKPOINT

Using P=1, N/B=3, R=5, Q=9, how much does Black's material balance change over the complete line? **Answer:** -1: the balance goes from -3 to -4. Count promotions and every recapture, not just the first gain.

CARRY THE IDEA INTO YOUR GAMES

A king without pawns is not automatically mated. Count active attackers and examine escapes toward friendly pieces.

WHAT THIS POSITION TEACHES

An exposed king gives the attacker checks and access to nearby squares. Coordinate pieces so the checks drive it into a worse net rather than toward safety.

HOW TO LOOK

Inspect open files, diagonals, and unprotected squares around the king. Calculate checks in an order that preserves the attack.

The defending king is on h3. Look for a defender that can be displaced or overloaded.